

MyDAW Operation Manual

A practical guide to recording, playback, editing, and project management

MyDAW is a macOS digital audio workstation for recording audio from a microphone or Core Audio interface, arranging multiple tracks, editing recordings, and mixing with AU or VST3 plug-ins.

1. What MyDAW Can Do

- Record mono or stereo audio on multiple tracks
- Play tracks together while viewing their waveforms
- Move, split, duplicate, trim, fade, and delete recording clips
- Move clips between tracks
- Snap clip edits to beats and edit with undo/redo
- Use BPM and a metronome while recording
- Insert AU or VST3 effects on tracks, FX channels, and the master channel
- Export the master output as a 24-bit WAV file
- Save and reopen complete projects

Recordings are written as 24-bit Linear PCM WAV files into the project's **Recordings** folder.

2. Before You Start

- Apple Silicon Mac
- A microphone or Core Audio audio interface
- Headphones or monitor speakers

Open **build/MyDAW.app** after building the application. Allow microphone access when macOS asks for permission.

3. Main Window

Area	Function
Top left	Rewind, stop, play, record arm, delete, save, open, metronome, and settings
Top center	Time, tempo, audio format, and storage status

Top right	Timeline zoom, waveform zoom, ruler mode, and master volume
Track headers	Track name, record arm, mono/stereo, input, mute, solo, volume, and pan
Timeline	Ruler, waveforms, recording clips, and the orange playhead

4. First Recording

1. Turn on the **R** button on the destination track.
2. Select the input channel and mono or stereo mode.
3. Click the ruler to choose the starting position.
4. Press Play or the space bar.
5. Perform or speak, then press Stop.

The recording is finalized as a WAV file in **Recordings**.

5. Playback and Transport

Operation	Result
Play	Starts playback at the playhead; armed tracks record at the same time.
Stop	Stops playback and finalizes an active recording.
Rewind	Returns the playhead to time zero.
Ruler click	Moves the playhead to the clicked position.

6. Editing Recording Clips

Selecting and Moving

Click a waveform clip to select it. Drag the selected clip to move it horizontally or to another track. During the drag, a box with the clip's original width and height follows the pointer. The move is committed when the mouse button is released.

Trimming and Fades

Drag the left or right edge to change the playback range without changing the source file. Drag the white top-left or top-right handles to set linear fade-in or fade-out durations.

Context Menu and History

- **Split at Cursor:** splits the clip at the playhead.

- **Duplicate Recording:** creates a copy after the original.
- **Delete Recording:** removes the selected clip.

Clip moves, trims, fades, splits, duplicates, and deletions support undo and redo. A complete drag is recorded as one edit.

7. Importing WAV Files

Drag a WAV file from Finder onto a waveform lane. It is copied into the project's **Recordings** folder and inserted at the current playhead position. The source file is not modified.

The file must match the current hardware sample rate and use 24-bit audio.

8. BPM, Ruler, and Metronome

Enter a value from 20 to 400 BPM in the TEMPO field. Use the ruler button to switch between time and bars/beats. Enable the metronome before starting playback or recording. Click timing and volume are available in the audio settings dialog.

9. Zoom and Navigation

Use the timeline zoom controls or slider to change horizontal scale. Use the waveform slider to change vertical scale. The ruler, waveform, playhead, and scrolling remain synchronized.

10. Plug-ins and Mixer

Insert AU or VST3 effects on a track, an FX channel, or the MASTER channel. Click an inserted plug-in name to open its GUI. The plug-in window stays in front of MyDAW while MyDAW is active; another application takes priority when it becomes active.

Use Sends to route a track to an FX channel. Each channel provides volume, pan, mute, solo, plug-in, and meter controls. Stop playback and recording before changing the plug-in graph.

11. Audio Settings and Recording Latency

Open the gear menu to choose input and output devices, buffer size, click timing, click volume, and additional recording compensation. Apply settings after stopping playback and recording. Positive recording compensation moves new clips earlier on the timeline.

12. Project Management and Transfer

Project Folder Structure

A MyDAW project is managed as one folder:

```
MySong/
├─ MySong.mydaw
└─ Recordings/
    └─ *.wav
```

The `.mydaw` file stores track settings, clip positions and edits, plug-in settings, BPM, ruler state, and other project information. Recorded and imported WAV files are stored in `Recordings/` and referenced with paths relative to the project folder.

Moving a Project to Another Environment

To move a project to another Mac or environment, copy or ZIP the entire project folder, including both the `.mydaw` file and `Recordings/`. Extract it at the destination and open the `.mydaw` file. The project and its recordings will remain together. Install the required AU/VST3 plug-ins separately on the destination system.

Keep the project folder structure unchanged. Do not rename, move, or delete `Recordings/` files while the project is in use.

Saving and Opening

Use Save or `Cmd-S` to save, and Open or `Cmd-O` to open a project.

13. Exporting the Master Mix

Choose **Export Master Mix...**, select a destination, enter start and end times in seconds, and press Export. The master signal path, including plug-ins and FX, is rendered in real time to a 24-bit Linear PCM WAV file.

14. Troubleshooting

Problem	Check
No recording	Microphone permission, input device, input channel, and the R button
No sound	Output device, master volume, mute buttons, and speakers
WAV cannot be imported	Sample rate and 24-bit format

Timing is offset	Buffer size and recording compensation
Missing audio after transfer	The complete project folder and its Recordings folder must be present

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